

Rushikesh Kulkarni

Engineering Strategist | Innovation Catalyst | Digital Advocate | DEI Champion | Global Mindset | \$2.1Bn Portfolio Impact

+91-9890313665 | enr.rushikesh@gmail.com, rushikesh_kulkarni@outlook.com | [in linkedin.com/in/kulkarnirushikesh](https://in.linkedin.com/in/kulkarnirushikesh) | [Video Resume](#)

Visionary Engineering Leader with 20+ years driving digital transformation, embedded systems innovation, and large-scale team scaling across global industrial automation, life safety, and consumer appliance domains, impacting \$2.1Bn+ product portfolio. Proven executive track record of accelerating product development cycles by 24%, scaling engineering teams by 600%, and delivering \$30M+ cost reductions through strategic technology leadership, innovation management, and operational excellence.

Core Skills

Strategic Leadership: P&L Ownership, Budget Oversight, Business Transformation, Global Team Scaling, Strategic Planning, Executive Stakeholder Management, Digital Strategy, Innovation Mindset

Engineering Excellence: Embedded Systems Development & Architecture, IoT, Connected Products, Electronics Design, Hardware & Firmware Development, Digital Transformation, AI/ML Implementation, Industry 4.0, Regulatory Compliance (UL, CE, BIS)

Operational Excellence: New Product Introduction (NPI), New Technology Introduction (NTI), VAVE/Cost Reduction, Design for Excellence DFX (DFSS, DFR, DFM, DFS, DFE), Process Optimization, Quality Improvement

Program Management: Project & Portfolio Management, Risk Management, Resource Forecasting, Agile/Waterfall/Hybrid Delivery, Change Management, Cross-functional Leadership, Cross-Regional Leadership

Innovation & IP: Innovation Culture, Technology Roadmap & Technology Strategy, IP Strategy, Problem Solving

People Leadership: Team Building, Succession Planning, Competency Development, Diversity, Equity Inclusion (DEI), Leadership Coaching, Talent Acquisition, Performance Management

Education

M.Tech. | Embedded Systems
BITS Pilani 2020
CGPA: 9.34

PGDBA | Operations & Marketing Management
Symbiosis Centre for Distance Learning 2010

B.E. | Electronics & Telecommunication
Pune University 2007

Core Leadership Impact

- **Accelerated product development cycles by 24%**, reducing time-to-market from 16 to 11 months through strategic process optimization and execution discipline, resulting organic revenue growth of 11% and introduction of 3 new product lines.
- **Scaled engineering teams by 600% (7 to 55 members)** by securing additional global business, increasing project ownership from 7% to 50% for high-risk programs.
- **Delivered \$30M+ cost reduction** through strategic VAVE/DtV programs across life safety, consumer electronics, industrial automation and electromechanical products.
- **Built innovation culture resulting in 20+ invention disclosures and 8 patents**, with 75% originating from India teams including breakthrough software/firmware domains.
- **Achieved 51% gender balance** from 15% through focused DEI initiatives and inclusive leadership transformation.
- **Spearheaded \$4.2Mn+ annual R&D budgets & \$2.1Bn Portfolio** with CAPEX/OPEX alignment, ensuring 90%+ on-time delivery performance across high-impact programs.

Work Experience

Chief Technology Officer (CTO) & Vice President, Engineering Sep 2023 – Present

General Industrial Controls Pvt Ltd (GIC)

- Reduced product development time by 24%, enabling accelerated market launches and improving engineering throughput across industrial automation portfolio.
- Delivered 90%+ on-time performance for new products through disciplined risk management, milestone tracking, and cross-functional program execution.
- Improved team productivity by 30% YoY through strategic planning, agile framework adoption, and operational excellence initiatives.
- Defined long-term engineering roadmap and business-aligned technology strategies for Board approval to propose new product line in industrial automation.
- Strategic Business Partner with P&L ownership, CAPEX/OPEX optimization expertise, establishing global delivery frameworks driving measurable revenue impact.
- Digital Transformation implementation using AI/ML, IoT, and Industry 4.0 solutions for manufacturing optimization, and intelligent automation systems.
- System engineer & architect with proven experience in design & development of complex embedded systems.
- Lead cross-regional, cross-functional teams delivering multi-million-dollar business outcomes for global customers while shaping India-focused R&D innovation ecosystems.
- Led multiple medium-to-large sized, moderately-to-highly complex projects simultaneously with enterprise-level program management discipline.
- Foster positive, high-performance work environment for 150+ member organization, achieving Great Place to Work recognition through inclusive leadership.

Senior Engineering Leader – Connected Products

Aug 2017– Sep 2023

Eaton India Innovation Centre LLP (EIIC)

- Built cross-functional & cross-regional teams enabling Connected Products development for global locations from India across harsh & hazardous environments.
- Led global product development in life safety, power management, and hazardous area communication domains with full end-to-end delivery accountability.
- Delivered \$15M in savings via strategic DtV/VAVE initiatives while maintaining regulatory compliance and operational excellence standards.
- Drove NPI/NTI programs, sustaining engineering excellence, and IP generation including 20 disclosures and 8 patents; 75% originated from India innovation centres.
- Scaled engineering team from 7 to 55 members (600% growth), strategically increasing project ownership by 41% through capability development and stakeholder confidence.
- Promoted 24% of roles internally and enabled 10%+ job rotations, reducing voluntary attrition to 3.7% from 8% while driving gender diversity transformation from 15% to 51%.

Executive Certifications

Digital Director | Director's Institute

ESG Expert | Director's Institute

Independent Director | Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA)

Digital Transformation | Indian School of Business (ISB)

Certified Scrum Master (CSM) | Agile Leadership

PRINCE2® Foundation & Practitioner | PeropleCert

Change Management | Harvard Mentor Manager (HMM)

Certified Agile Team Manager (CATM) | Agilest

Six Sigma Green Belt | Honeywell & Eaton (Operational Excellence)

Awards & Recognition

Indian Achievers Award 2024 –

Honoured for excellence in engineering leadership and driving innovation-led growth in embedded systems and industrial automation.

CII DigiAI Award 2024 – Recognized for successful implementation of AI/ML technologies in manufacturing processes, enabling predictive diagnostics.

Eaton's Electrical Sector Continuous Improvement Award 2022 – Awarded for championing continuous improvement initiatives enhancing engineering delivery, technical capabilities.

Whirlpool Pinnacle Award 2016 – Received for exceptional project delivery and strategic business impact from remote engineering centre, contributing significantly to global innovation pipeline.

Additional Information

Language Proficiency: English, Hindi, and Marathi

Volunteering & Ecosystem Engagement

Mentor | Atal Tinkering Lab (NITI Aayog Initiative)
Guiding school innovators on design thinking & prototyping of STEM concepts to foster innovation mindsets.

Mentor | Mentor Together
Supporting underprivileged youth through structured mentorship focused on professional growth, and life skills.

Industry-Academia Collaboration Leader
Driving curriculum alignment, student project incubation, and technical enablement by bridging gaps between academia and industry needs.

- Developed enterprise-level NPI efficacy framework and led DFSS adoption, improving Design Maturity Index from 0.8 to 1.3 across teams with 10 professional certifications.
- Built knowledge-sharing platforms (Knowledge Café, EoTo) driving >30% improvement in knowledge retention, competency development, and team readiness.
- Improved sustaining engineering footprint to 22% while achieving 95% On-Time Delivery (OTD) and 95% First Pass Yield (FPY) through DMAIC project implementations with 39% TAT improvement.
- Enabled transparent, high-trust culture increasing bi-directional engagement score from 54% to 67% through dedicated communication initiatives.
- Created comprehensive Resource Planner framework for effective tracking, monitoring, and optimization of large-scale team operations.

Senior Delivery Manager – Embedded Systems & Head HMI CoE Feb 2014 – Aug 2017
Whirlpool of India Ltd

- Established HMI Centre of Excellence (CoE) at Global Capability Centre (GCC), enabling seamless collaboration across platform, product, and regional teams in India, China, and North America.
- Improved engineering productivity by 25–30% YoY through agile methodology scaling, structured process alignment, and cross-functional optimization.
- Led strategic product cost reduction initiatives delivering \$14.8M in savings during FY16–17 through value engineering and supply chain optimization.
- Executed strategic business transition of global small appliance product line from Shenzhen to Pune, ensuring 100% customer continuity and enabling cost-effective localization.
- Established comprehensive in-house validation laboratory and project management framework (WPM) to improve quality standards and reduce development errors.
- Designed and delivered first audio-enabled blender "Torrent Speaks" for visually impaired users in <5 months, promoting inclusive innovation and accessibility leadership.
- Developed in-house laboratory capabilities to ensure pre-compliance validation & comprehensive utilization mechanisms across product development lifecycle.
- As Regional Competency Lead (RCL) for Whirlpool of India, elevated team competency score to 99.95% for 120-member organization across embedded hardware and EMC domains.

Project Leader – Industrial Automation

Jun 2008 – Jan 2014

Honeywell Technology Solutions Labs Pvt Ltd (HTSL)

- Led redesign & East-4-East NPD projects for business continuity delivering 30% cost-optimized solutions for APAC market expansion.
- Executed strategic localization projects achieving 30%+ cost savings while supporting global component lifecycle management and supply chain optimization.
- Managed comprehensive component lifecycle across 1M+ parts, improving supply chain responsiveness, reducing obsolescence risks, and enhancing manufacturing efficiency.
- Delivered process improvement initiatives reducing obsolescence-related issues while enhancing manufacturing efficiency and quality standards.
- Awarded Key Talent Personnel (KTP) designation with sustained "Above the Rate" performance excellence across 10 consecutive appraisal cycles.

Preceding Experience

Graduate Trainee Engineer

Sep 2007 – May 2008

Bosch Ltd

- Handled electronics design projects, spare parts management systems, and implemented Six Sigma process improvement practices.

Lab Assistant

Aug 2005 – Aug 2007

Nashik Municipal Corporation (NMC)

- Conducted analytical laboratory work and quality control procedures in municipal infrastructure development projects.

Executive Leadership Development Recognition

- Future Leadership Accelerator (FLX), Eaton 2021** – Selected for elite leadership development program for high-potential executives driving organizational transformation.
- Future Leadership Pipeline (FLP), Whirlpool 2016** – Nominated as emerging leader with executive succession potential across global engineering leadership roles.
- Key Talent Personnel (KTP), Honeywell 2011** – Identified as high-potential engineering leader for sustained excellence in delivery, innovation.